ANNIVERSARY

YOUTH UPRISINGS

STATE OF UNREST

TELANGANA AGITATION, 1969-70

Hyderabad

The movement for bifurcation was the result of severe misgivings in Telangana that their interests were being curtailed

The 1956 reorganisation of states in the south failed to usher in equitable development of all regions. The Telangana agitation was one of the outcomes. The movement for bifurcation of the state of Andhra Pradesh was the result of severe misgivings among the people of the Telangana region that their interests were being curtailed. It all came to a boil in 1969. While factional politics inspired the agitation in its initial days, the ferment among the youth, especially students, stemmed from a sense of frustration at the lack of job opportunities. In the Telangana region, it engendered a strong, sub-regional agitation. Incensed students boycotted classes and took to the streets. They were joined by government staff and politicians deserting the Congress to join the protests. More than 300 students died in police firing and clashes while all the students eventually lost an academic year, an unprecedented sacrifice then.

Unable to check the protests, Indira Gandhi, on a fleeting visit to Hyderabad, assured the agitation's leaders that Telangana's surpluses would be used for its development and appealed to students to call off their agitation. An economic package to spur the development of the region was announced. Meanwhile, the agitation spawned the Telangana Praja Samithi (TPS) which won 10 of the 14 seats in the region in the 1971 parliamentary polls. But just a year later, it won just one seat in the assembly poll. With that the demand for statehood too went on the backburner. ■

–Amarnath K. Menon

A 44-YEAR WAR **The Telangana Rashtra Samithi, led by K. Chandrashekar Rao, revived the campaign in 2000 involving students and the youth (several even committed suicide for the cause). Telangana finally got statehood in 2014.**